Fiscal Year:	FY 2021	**Task Last Updated:**	FY 03/04/2021
PI Name:	Oza, Anand Ph.D.		
Project Title:	Phase Transitions in Colloid-Polymer Mixtures in Microgravity		
Division Name:	Physical Sciences		
Program/Discipline:			
Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:	COMPLEX FLUIDS/SOFT MATTER--Complex Fluids		
Joint Agency Name:		**TechPort:**	No
Human Research Program Elements:	None		
Human Research Program Risks:	None		
Space Biology Element:	None		
Space Biology Cross-Element Discipline:	None		
Space Biology Special Category:	None		
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Comments:			
Project Type:	Ground,Physical Sciences Informatics (PSI)	**Solicitation / Funding Source:**	2017 Physical Sciences NNH17ZTT001N-17PSI-E: Use of the NASA Physical Sciences Informatics System – Appendix E
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No. of Post Docs:	0	**No. of PhD Degrees:**	0
No. of PhD Candidates:	1	**No. of Master' Degrees:**	0
No. of Master's Candidates:	0	**No. of Bachelor's Degrees:**	0
No. of Bachelor's Candidates:	0	**Monitoring Center:**	NASA GRC
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Flight Program:			
Flight Assignment:	NOTE: End date changed to 11/04/2022 per NSSC information. (Ed. 10/20/21)		
Key Personnel Changes/Previous PI:	March 2021 report: no changes		
COI Name (Institution):	Khusid, Boris Ph.D. (New Jersey Institute of Technology) Kondic, Lou Ph.D. (New Jersey Institute of Technology) Meyer, William Ph.D. (Universities Space Research Association/NASA Glenn Research Center)		
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Task Description:	Adding non-adsorbing polymers to a suspension of colloidal spheres induces attractive forces between spheres originating from the presence of depletion zones around the spheres. We propose to work on analyzing the data on colloid/non-adsorbing polymer mixtures acquired in microgravity in NASA-supported projects Binary Colloidal Alloy Test (BCAT) 3-6. In our recently completed project (Structure evolution during phase separation in colloids under microgravity, NNX16AQ79G, PI: Kondic, 8/16/2016 - 8/15/2018) we analyzed the data on suspensions of hard spheres collected in Physics of Hard Spheres (PHaSE) experiments. As part of that project, we have formulated a new model that includes up-to-date information about the nature of phase transitions in suspensions of hard spheres. This model, coupled with the data acquired in the NASA-supported projects, already allowed us to explain some important observations of the crystallization kinetics in suspensions of hard spheres. These results were presented at the 2017 and 2018 American Society for Gravitational and Space Research (ASGSR) meetings. As a part of the proposed work, we plan to develop a new model for phase transitions in colloid-polymer mixtures. The model that we propose to develop will be based on the one that we developed for suspensions of hard-spheres, but will involve significantly more complicated physics. The predictions of the model will be compared to the experimental data residing in the NASA Physical Sciences Informatics (PSI) system, as well as to relevant Earth-based experiments.
Rationale for HRP Directed Research:	
Research Impact/Earth Benefits:	Colloids have been studied extensively because of the many similarities they share with behaviors of atoms in a microscopic setting. The fact that the colloidal particles are macroscopic makes colloids much easier to observe than atomic systems, and yet their behavior is such that they may be viewed as "big atoms." The addition of polymer into a colloidal mixture leads to the possibility of three-phase coexistence. This project thus has the potential to give us new fundamental insights into the phase transition kinetics of systems with complex phase behavior. Experiments with colloids have applications in fields such as materials science, engineering, and pharmaceuticals. Understanding phase transitions on an atomic scale is extremely useful in making and working with materials that are used to manufacture electronics and other products that we use in our everyday lives.
Task Progress:	Colloidal particles can be considered as blocks for building materials, like atoms for forming molecules and crystals. The recent surge of activity in assembly of colloidal crystals is motivated not only by scientific curiosity but also by myriad technologies in materials engineering, electronics, life science, and chemical and pharmaceutical industries. Colloidal systems undergo phase transformations analogous to transformations in atomic and molecular systems. Therefore, they are considered as excellent model systems for the study of phase transitions since the particle motions can be observed by optical video microscopy and tracked by image processing. However, the rich variety of colloidal structures observed in numerous terrestrial experiments could also have been influenced by gravity effects, such as particle sedimentation, convection, and jamming, which compete with colloidal forces during the slowly evolving structure formation. In this research program, we first process NASA PSI video microscopy images to reveal the growth kinetics of colloid-polymer mixtures. We next conduct computer simulations of phase transitions in colloid-polymer mixtures under the conditions of microgravity experiments. Comparison of simulation results with data acquired from images recorded in microgravity experiments for over 5 orders of magnitude in time and more than 3 orders of magnitude in domain size will provide for the first time the unique opportunity to rigorously test theoretical predictions for the kinetics of phase transitions. Analysis of these images will be used to develop new coupled models, combining phase-field models for the initial stage of phase separation and crystallization models for the development of larger structures. The research results will provide recommendations for further development of theories, simulations, and ground-based experiments on phase transformations in advanced materials. We first process NASA PSI video microscopy images to reveal the growth kinetics of colloid-polymer mixtures. We used the free software ImageJ to remove the extraneous background, adjust the brightness/contrast, and smooth the image, yielding a time-sequence of enhanced images that can be characterized quantitatively. We then developed two measures for describing the time evolution of the length scale separating colloid-rich domains. One method uses the structure factor, and the other the autocorrelation. Taken together, both methods show phase separation, with linear growth of domains as time increases. Characterizing the length scale using the autocorrelation appears to be more robust, so we will adopt that measure going forward. We have also developed a theoretical model for simulating phase separation in colloid-polymer systems. Our starting point is the Cahn-Hilliard equation for the dynamics of the colloid volume fraction, which is assumed to be a function of both space in two dimensions and time. Its dynamics is driven by the chemical potential, which is derived from a free energy functional. We assume that the free energy can be split into two parts: one corresponding to the colloid, and the other to the polymer, the latter modeling the weakly attractive interactions between colloids. The free energy also contains a gradient-term that accounts for the diffuse nature of the interface between phases, as is typical in phase-field models. Our model differs from others in that the mobility is concentration-dependent; that is, the mobility decreases as the colloid volume fraction increases, and goes to zero as the crystal structure is approached. We expect this feature to significantly influence the simulated phase separation dynamics. We proceeded to write a code in MATLAB for simulating the governing equations. The code uses a pseudospectral method in space and a modified Runge-Kutta time-stepping scheme. We validated our code against the results of a linear stability analysis, and performed convergence studies both in the time step and number of spatial grid points. Preliminary numerical simulations of the governing equations show that the system does indeed exhibit phase separation, with relatively colloid-rich areas formed amongst a background of colloid-poor ones. Our current and future directions will involve further characterization of the BCAT images. We also plan to explore other image processing techniques, with a view to generating higher-quality enhanced images. We plan to characterize the phase separation process by plotting the dominant length scale, as quantified by the autocorrelation function, and then assess the dependence of the growth rate on system parameters (colloid volume fraction, polymer size, etc.). We also plan to explore more advanced image processing techniques; specifically, we could identify the centers and sizes of domains, and assess the positional order (or lack thereof) of these domains. We also plan to extend the modeling framework described previously to describe the physics of colloid-polymer mixtures, with a view to comparing our results with the BCAT 3-6 experiments. Specifically, we will incorporate hydrodynamic interactions into the modeling framework, since the role of hydrodynamic interactions in colloid-polymer

	phase separation has been the subject of controversy in the literature. Ultimately, the close comparison between theory and experiment will yield novel insights into the physical underpinnings of phase separation in systems comprised of constituents with weakly attractive interactions.
Bibliography Type:	Description: (Last Updated: 03/24/2025)
Abstracts for Journals and Proceedings	Barnes L, Khusid B, Kondic L, Meyer WV, Oza AU. "Continuum modeling of colloid-polymer mixtures in microgravity." Intended to be presented at the American Physical Society March Meeting, Denver, Colorado, March 2-6, 2020 (cancelled due to COVID). Bulletin of the American Physical Society. 2020 Mar;65(1):Abstract M71.00241. https://meetings.aps.org/Meeting/MAR20/Session/M71.241 , Mar-2020
Abstracts for Journals and Proceedings	Barnes L, Khusid B, Kondic L, Meyer WV, Oza AU. "Modelling of colloid-polymer mixtures in microgravity." Presented at the 36th Annual Meeting of the American Society for Gravitational and Space Research, Virtual Meeting, November 5-6, 2020. Abstract G20. 36th Annual Meeting of the American Society for Gravitational and Space Research, Virtual Meeting, November 5-6, 2020. , Nov-2020